

China Talent Introduction Policy Quarterly Briefing — Q2 2026

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What's Inside

本期关键词

Work permit processing time reduced to **6 working days** nationwide

R Visa (Talent Visa) valid for **5–10 years**, multiple entries

Salary thresholds strictly enforced in Beijing and Shanghai — **6×** for Category

A, **4×** for Category B

“Reverse application” for permanent residency now available — apply from overseas without prior China residency

Social insurance now mandatory for all foreign employees (“five insurances”)

2026 National Foreign Expert Projects offer **RMB 200,000–500,000** in funding

Three numbers that matter

The national average processing time for foreigner's work permits has been reduced to 6 working days — down from 20 working days previously, representing a 70% reduction in administrative friction.

R Visa (Talent Visa) holders receive 5–10 year, multiple-entry visas with stays up to 180 days per visit, and **visa fees and expedite fees are waived** — making China's talent visa one of the most generous in the world.

Beijing and Shanghai now strictly enforce salary multipliers — Category A requires **6×** the local average monthly wage (approx. RMB 71,622/month in Beijing), Category B requires **4×** (approx. RMB 47,748/month), representing a **~50% increase** from previous flexible enforcement levels.

What changed this quarter

"Work Permit + Social Security Card" integration fully implemented — no physical work permit card required

Foreigners holding tourist or stay visas can now apply for work permits within China

"One application, no-meeting approval, fully online" nationwide

National Foreign Expert Projects launched with RMB 200,000–500,000 funding per project

"Reverse application" for permanent residency introduced — apply from overseas

Part 1: Work Permit System Overview

1.1 The Three-Tier Classification System

China’s foreigner work permit system categorizes applicants into three tiers based on qualifications, skills, and labor market needs:

Category	Name	Key Features	Quota
Category A	Foreign High-End Talent	No age, education, or work experience limits	No quota limit
Category B	Foreign Professional Talent	Bachelor’s degree + 2 years relevant experience; age ≤ Chinese retirement age	Market-based limits
Category C	Other Foreign Personnel	Meets domestic labor market needs	Subject to national quota

1.2 Salary-Based Entry Thresholds (2026 Update)

Since February 2026, Beijing and Shanghai have strictly enforced salary-based entry thresholds for Category A and B work permits:

Category	Salary Requirement	Beijing (2025 avg wage: RMB 11,937/mo)	Shanghai (2025 avg wage: RMB 12,434/mo)
Category A	≥ 6× local average monthly wage	≥ RMB 71,622/month	≥ RMB 74,604/month
Category B	≥ 4× local average monthly wage	≥ RMB 47,748/month	≥ RMB 49,736/month

The minimum salary threshold has increased by **approximately 50%** from previous flexible enforcement levels. Systems will **automatically block** submissions that do not meet these figures.

City-by-city reference wage levels (2025 basis):

City / Region	2025 Average Monthly Wage
Shanghai	RMB 12,434
Beijing	RMB 11,937
Guangzhou	RMB 9,183
Shenzhen	RMB 9,183
Hangzhou	RMB 8,433
Suzhou	RMB 8,254

1.3 Alternative Pathways

Applicants who do not meet the salary threshold may still qualify through:

Points-based system: Category A requires 85+ points; Category B requires 60+ points

Local “High-Precision and Urgently-Needed” talent recognition (varies by city)

Shanghai Science and Technology Innovation Occupation List

Other diversified talent recognition policies

1.4 Work Permit + Social Security Card Integration

The “Work Permit + Social Security Card” integration (证卡融合集成) is now fully implemented:

Work permit applications, extensions, changes, and cancellations are processed **entirely online** through the Foreigners Working in China Management Service System

Foreigners **no longer need to obtain a physical work permit card** after entry

Those with existing physical permits follow the “no change, no replacement” principle — conversion occurs upon next extension or change

National average processing time reduced to 6 working days

“One application, no-meeting approval, fully online” implemented nationwide

“One window” service for work permit and residence permit applications

1.5 Application Process

Basic applicant requirements:

At least 18 years old

Good health

No criminal record

Has a confirmed employer within China

Possesses professional skills or knowledge required for the position

The work meets China's economic and social development needs

Key documents required:

Work permit application form (online, signed by applicant, company-stamped)

Work experience certificate (from previous employers)

Highest degree certificate (with authentication if obtained overseas)

No-criminal-record certificate (issued within 6 months, with authentication)

Health examination certificate (issued within 6 months)

Employment contract or appointment letter (in Chinese)

Special provisions:

Category A talent: **No age, education, or work experience limits**

Category A talent: **Commitment system** applies for work experience, degree, and no-criminal-record certificates

Foreigners holding valid visas or residence permits may apply **directly within**

China

Those holding tourist or stay visas may now apply for work permits

1.6 System Updates (2026)

Recent system upgrades introduced several structural changes:

Continuous employment/education timeline requirement:

The former "Work Experience" section has been redesigned as "Work and Education Experience"

Applicants must list work, education, and unemployment periods **without any gaps**

Missing months will cause system errors

Document rules & name formatting:

Only 26 English letters and compliant separators (space, hyphen, apostrophe, dot) may be used

No accented characters, numbers, Chinese characters, or special symbols allowed

All uploaded documents, except passport, must now be in **PDF format**

Expired permit handling:

If a permit expires, special procedures apply

Part 2: Talent Visa (R Visa)

2.1 What is the R Visa?

The R Visa (Talent Visa) is issued to **foreign high-level talent and urgently-needed specialized personnel** that meet China's national development needs. Recipients must meet the Category A (Foreign High-End

Talent) standards under the Foreigners Working in China Classification Standards.

2.2 Application Process

Step 1: Inviting entity applies for Confirmation Letter:

Submit application to the provincial-level foreign work management department

Submit online: application form, invitation letter, and R Visa qualification 证明材料

Department issues the **Confirmation Letter for Foreign High-End Talent** within **5 working days**

Step 2: Applicant applies for R Visa at embassy/consulate:

Visa application form

Passport (valid for 6+ months) with photo

Printed Confirmation Letter for Foreign High-End Talent

Other materials as required

The entire process is available **online, without requiring paper documents.**

2.3 R Visa Benefits

Benefit

Details